

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART TWO · CRAFT

CHAPTER 5 · EDITING

*Editing is film's dark art. Every cut decides what you see,
and what you don't.*

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

The Blair Witch Project · 1999 · 81 min · written and directed by
Daniel Myrick & Eduardo Sánchez · Artisan

*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some
information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you
press play" and resume after the credits.*

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner. This one is watched over Halloween.

Two witch films, one question: when does the film cut to the witch? The Blair Witch Project never does. It pretends nobody edited it at all — three students' lost tapes — and every cut keeps the thing in the woods out of frame to the last shot.

The Witch is cut like a classic, slow and patient and nearly invisible, and it shows you the witch about ten minutes in. One hides her with the edit. The other reveals her with it. Both want you afraid of the same woods.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

THE BLAIR WITCH PROJECT

1999 · 81 min · written and directed by Daniel Myrick & Eduardo Sánchez · Artisan

Three film students hike into a Maryland forest to make a documentary about a local legend. A year later, their footage is found.

Why it is on the ballot. It is the film that made found footage a genre, and it is a masterclass in editing that pretends not to be edited. Every cut is disguised as a camera switching off, and almost everything frightening happens in the gaps between shots.



STILL ONLINE

THE BLAIR WITCH PROJECT

A year before anyone could buy a ticket, this film had a website that never once admitted it was a film. Police reports, a legend, a missing-persons case. People believed it, and it is one of the most enjoyable pieces of marketing anybody has ever run. It is still there, at the address it had in 1999.

haxan.com/blairwitch

01

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

THE ACTORS SHOT IT THEMSELVES

Heather Donahue, Joshua Leonard and Michael C. Williams, playing characters with their own first names, spent eight days in October 1997 in the woods near Seneca Creek in Montgomery County, Maryland. They operated both cameras. Myrick and Sánchez stayed out of sight and left the next day's instructions in film cans hidden in milk crates, cutting the food rations as the days went on.

TWO CAMERAS, TWO FORMATS

A CP-16 16mm black-and-white film camera for the "documentary," and a Hi8 camcorder for the behind-the-scenes video. Neal Fredericks is the credited cinematographer.

IT COST ALMOST NOTHING, BY ANY ACCOUNT

The eight-day shoot has been put at \$20,000, \$35,000 and \$60,000 by the filmmakers themselves in different interviews; the honest version is “well under a hundred thousand dollars,” with post-production and the Sundance finish taking the total somewhere between \$200,000 and \$750,000. It grossed \$248.6 million worldwide.

02

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THROUGHOUT

Two cameras, two films

One camera shoots grainy black-and-white film. The other is colour video.

Why it matters: Every switch between them is a cut, dressed up as somebody picking up a different camera. Notice which one you are in when things go wrong.

THE FIRST NIGHT

Cut to black

At night the film keeps dropping into darkness, sometimes with only sound.

Why it matters: A black screen is an edit. The film is choosing not to show you, and your imagination does the rest — for free, which is roughly what the budget allowed.

THE MORNINGS

What happened while the camera was off?

Things appear outside the tent overnight, and the film skips straight from the night to the discovery.

Why it matters: The horror lives in the missing footage. The edit makes you fill the gap, and you fill it with something worse than they could have shot.

THE LAST SHOT

The corner

Remember the story someone tells early on about a man who made children face the corner. Then watch the final seconds.

Why it matters: The film cuts at the exact moment you might finally see something. It is the most famous cut in modern horror, and it shows nothing.

03

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

The ending was solved in the cutting room

Artisan wanted something more explicit, and the directors shot alternative endings, including Mike hanged and Mike on a stick-figure frame. They threw both away. The corner image came first, because they had no effects money, and the Rustin Parr interview that explains it was added afterwards in the edit so the last shot would land.

OPEN

Around twenty hours became eighty-one minutes

The shoot produced roughly 19 to 22 hours of footage, and Myrick and Sánchez cut it themselves over about eight months. A film that looks like nobody touched it is one of the most heavily edited horror films of its decade. Their rule, in Myrick's words: anything that felt like a movie had to go.

From mid-1998 the film's website presented the disappearance as fact, with police reports and a legend. Days before release the Sci-Fi Channel aired *Curse of the Blair Witch*, a full mockumentary in which director Ben Rock gave interviewees contradictory backstories, cut their unscripted answers together and artificially aged the "archive" material. The oft-repeated line that IMDb listed the actors as missing or dead is folklore; nobody has produced the page.

01 The film pretends nobody edited it. Where did you feel somebody's hand anyway?

02 You never see the witch. Did that make it scarier, or did you feel cheated?

03 Most of the horror happens between the shots. What did you picture there?

Where to watch

Find it here → [The Blair Witch Project on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: Film Stories · the AV Club · Box Office Mojo

THE CUT SHOULD DISAPPEAR

EDITORS WORKED IT OUT BY HAND

Through the first half of the twentieth century, Hollywood editors built a set of habits for joining shots so smoothly that nobody noticed the joins. Cut in the middle of a movement. Keep the camera on one side of the action. Match where people are looking. None of it was law. It was craft, passed from editor to assistant.

A BRITISH BOOK WROTE IT DOWN

In 1953 Karel Reisz, working with a committee of the British Film Academy chaired by Thorold Dickinson, published *The Technique of Film Editing*, which collected what working editors actually did. It became the standard textbook for decades and taught the habits as the rules of **continuity editing**, with one goal stated plainly: the audience should never notice the cut.

MEANWHILE, IN MOSCOW

Thirty years earlier Lev Kuleshov had intercut one neutral close-up of the actor Ivan Mosjoukine with a bowl of soup, a girl in a coffin and a woman on a divan. Audiences praised the actor's range for hunger, grief and desire. The face never changed; the cut did all the work. Worth knowing that the footage is lost and the story comes to us second-hand through Pudovkin's 1929 account, and that a 1992 attempt to replicate it failed. The idea survived anyway, because every horror film runs on it.

THREE WAYS TO CUT

ONE

CONTINUITY

Smooth, invisible joins that keep you inside the story.

Almost every Hollywood film
· The Witch

TWO

COLLISION

Shots slammed together so the meaning comes from the clash rather than from either shot.

Battleship Potemkin · the
Psycho shower · Requiem
for a Dream

THREE

THE CUT THAT SHOWS

Jump cuts, black screens, a camera switching off. The edit is on display.

Breathless · The Blair Witch
Project · Uncut Gems

A horror film usually runs on the first and the third at once: invisible cutting to keep you inside, and one visible cut to make you jump.

HOW LONG IS A SHOT?

Editing has one number attached to it that anybody can check: the average shot length, the runtime divided by the number of shots. It will not tell you whether a film is any good, but it will tell you how hard it is working to hold you, and it separates eras more cleanly than almost anything else you can measure.



2s

4s

6s

8s

10s

12s

14s

SIXTY SECONDS OF SCREEN TIME, CUT SIX WAYS

2.4 seconds a shot · *The Bourne Supremacy*, 2004



4.7 seconds a shot · *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind*, 2004



7.1 seconds a shot · *The Blair Witch Project*, 1999



9.5 seconds a shot · *Touch of Evil*, 1958



11.4 seconds a shot · *Citizen Kane*, 1941



13.5 seconds a shot · *The Witch*, 2015



The pale notches are published counts. The two in orange are this chapter's own films, timed in house rather than taken from anyone's table. Everything bunches between five and nine seconds, which is most of cinema; the room either side of that bunch is where a film is doing something deliberate.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

The **Kuleshov effect**: viewers read emotion into a shot based on the shot beside it. A face, then the dark, and you decide what the face saw.

WHY THESE FILMS

Chapter 4 decided what goes in the frame. This chapter decides what happens between frames. Blair Witch hides its edits and its witch. The Witch hides neither, and dares you to stay frightened anyway.

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S FILM FORUM

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from Variety, the AV Club, Film Stories, Slate, Box Office Mojo and interviews with the filmmakers. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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